The Future of EFL Students' Creativity in English Writing: Thinking, Acting, and Learning in Higher Education in the Age of AI

Abstract

Applying Artificial Intelligence (AI) writing tools in language classrooms in universities is becoming increasingly popular since they simplify instructional tasks for English as a Foreign Language (EFL) teachers and offer the ability to enhance writing accuracy and support quality writing for EFL students (Baron, 2023; Roe et al., 2023). However, teachers' concerns about using these sophisticated AI writing tools highlight a re-evaluation of integrating these technologies into teaching and learning of EFL writing, particularly with regard to ethical issues and cognitive-linguistic challenges. The former includes students' plagiarism and academic integrity in writing assignments, whereas the latter refers to discouraging their thinking and creativity in writing (Lund and Wang, 2023; Roe et al., 2023). In contrast, the process writing approach can minimise these concerns as it emphasises the importance of linguistic writing skills, and encourages students' cognitive functions, including creativity in writing (Bailey, 2015; Hyland, 2019; 2021; Johnson, 2024). This paper examines the transformative potential of language education, especially writing, in higher education settings by integrating insights from the human-driven writing approach with the neuroscience perspective. It also contributes to the discourse on innovative language education

practices that are replicable across diverse learning contexts, coupled with the recognition that language education remains both influential and prepared for the future. Moreover, this article argues for adopting the process writing approach as a potential solution to support students' creativity and writing skills development over AI writing tools by promoting critical thinking, fostering effective communication, strengthening students' active engagement in English writing activities, and preserving the human dimensions that ultimately lead to meaningful learning within higher education contexts.